

WEEKLY BUSINESS SESSION – June 24, 2026

9:00 a.m. – Anne Basker Auditorium

600 N.W. Sixth Street, Grants Pass, OR 97526

Present: Ron A. Smith, Chair-Commissioner; Colene M. Martin, Vice-Chair-Commissioner and Gary L. Richardson, Commissioner, Nikole Guzman, Recorder

These are meeting minutes only. Only text enclosed in quotation marks reports a speaker's exact words.

Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m. followed by the Pledge of Allegiance.

Items discussed were as follows:

1. **CALL MEETING TO ORDER:** Pursuant to notice through the media and in conformance with the Public Meeting Law, Ron Smith, Chair, called the meeting to order at 9:00 a.m.

2. **DECLARE A POTENTIAL CONFLICT OF INTEREST:** The commissioners reserved their right to declare a potential conflict of interest

3. **Public Hearing: Proceedings to Legalize a Portion of Caves Camp Road No. 4120**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:01 a.m.

Neil Burgess, Engineer, presented the final step of the three-step legalization process for a portion of Cave Camp Road associated with the upcoming replacement of the bridge deck crossing the West Fork of Williams Creek. Burgess reviewed the historical establishment of the roadway in 1891 and explained that a realignment approved by the Board of County Commissioners in 1939 had never been formally legalized despite remaining in continuous public use for approximately 86 years.

Burgess reviewed the survey completed by the Oregon Department of Transportation, historical Commissioners' Journals, field notes, and property descriptions demonstrating that the existing roadway alignment has been recognized by adjoining property owners and reflected within County records for decades. He stated that legalization would not require acquisition of additional right-of-way, would not result in compensation to adjoining property owners, and would satisfy statutory requirements allowing the bridge replacement project to proceed. He further advised that all affected property owners had received notice of the public hearing and no objections had been received. (Exhibit 1- PowerPoint)

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):

Judy Aherns, Josephine County, asked about the cost and downside of legalizing the portion to the county. County Engineer Burgess responded that the legalization itself would not create additional costs to the County beyond the existing federal bridge replacement project and would not constitute a taking of private property.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Order No. 2026-038: In the Matter of Authorizing Legalization of a Portion of Caves Camp Road County Road. No. 4120, Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Public Hearing closed at 9:08 a.m.

4. **Public Hearing: Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District for Fiscal Year 2026-2027**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:08 a.m.

Arthur O'Hare, Budget Officer, reported that the Budget Committee approved the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget on June 4, 2026, the approved budget was published on June 12, 2026, and the required budget hearing had been conducted on June 17, 2026. O'Hare recommended formal adoption of the budget.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak):

None heard

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-023; In the Matter of Adoption of the 2026-27 Budget, and Making Appropriations for the Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District, Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Delegation of Minutes of the Public Hearing of the Resolution No. 2026-023; In the Matter of Adoption of the 2026-27 Budget, and Making Appropriations for the Josephine County 4-H/Extension Service District, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0

Public Hearing closed at 9:11 a.m.

5. Public Hearing: Josephine County Law Enforcement Service District for Fiscal Year 2025-2026

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:11 a.m.

Arthur O'Hare, Budget Officer, reported that the Law Enforcement Service District Budget Committee approved the proposed Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget on June 4, 2026, publication requirements had been completed, and the required public hearing occurred on June 17, 2026. He requested formal adoption of the budget.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak): None heard

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-024; In the Matter of Adoption of the 2026-27 Budget, and Making Appropriations for the Josephine County Law Enforcement Service District, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Delegation of Minutes of the Public Hearing of the Resolution No. 2026-024; In the Matter of Adoption of the 2026-27 Budget, and Making Appropriations for the Josephine County Law Enforcement Service District, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Public Hearing closed at 9:15 a.m.

6. Public Hearing: Josephine County Budget for Fiscal Year 2026-27

- a. **Resolution No. 2026-025; In the Matter of Adopting the Budget for the Fiscal Year 2026-27**
- b. **Resolution No. 2026-026; In the Matter of Adopting a Supplemental Budget and Making Appropriations and Budget Adjustments for the Fiscal Year 2025-26**
- c. **Resolution No. 2026-029 In the Matter of Levying Ad Valorem Property Tax Rates and Local Option Levy Taxes for Josephine County, Oregon for Fiscal Year 2026-27**

Commissioner Smith opened the public hearing at 9:15 a.m.

Arthur O'Hare, Budget Officer, explained reviewed the budget process completed by the Budget Committee, publication requirements, and the Board's authority under Oregon Budget Law to adopt the budget and consider amendments not exceeding statutory limitations. O'Hare presented two proposed additions to the Internal Service Fund that had been deferred during Budget Committee deliberations, including one full-time Help Desk Support Technician for the Information Technology Department and one half-time Law Library Assistant position funded through dedicated State Law Library revenues.

Information Technology Director Ken addressed the Board regarding the Help Desk Support Technician request. He explained that increasing support demands generated by expanded Sheriff's Office operations, combined with a growing backlog of technology service requests, have resulted in senior technical staff performing routine help desk duties rather than focusing on cybersecurity, network infrastructure, and

enterprise technology responsibilities. He stated that the additional position would improve response times while allowing technical staff to focus on higher-level County technology needs.

Budget Officer O'Hare also explained that the proposed Law Library Assistant position would be funded entirely through dedicated State Law Library revenues and would not impact General Fund resources.

Commissioner Smith opened the floor to Public Testimony: (Each person given Three (3) Minutes to speak): Judy Aherns, Josephine County requested clarification regarding the public hearing process for the budget resolutions. She expressed concern that members of the public were uncertain when testimony could be provided on each budget item and encouraged the Board to ensure opportunities for public comment were clearly communicated.

Marc Kirby, Josephine County expressed concern that the proposed Fiscal Year 2026-2027 budget relies on reserve funds to balance expenditures and questioned the County's long-term financial sustainability. He also discussed Sheriff staffing appropriations, projected reserve depletion, and recent Board actions related to personnel authority and labor negotiations.

Cris Kirby, Josephine County expressed concern regarding County employee compensation compared to average resident income. She stated that increasing personnel expenditures could create an unsustainable financial burden on taxpayers and encouraged greater fiscal restraint.

Kathy Millard, Grants Pass, urged the Board to reconsider adoption of the proposed budget, citing concerns about the use of reserve funds and future financial stability. She encouraged the Board to exercise prudent stewardship of public resources and carefully consider long-term budget impacts.

Herman Berchiger Senior, Josephine County, questioned appropriations for vacant Sheriff's Office positions and asked how funding for unfilled positions is managed. He encouraged the Board to be more fiscally conservative and to closely monitor departmental spending.

Mark Jones, Josephine County, reviewed historical General Fund reserve balances and discussed long-term financial projections. He expressed concern regarding declining reserves and encouraged the Board to maintain financial stability while protecting essential County services.

Chris Collins, Josephine County, spoke in support of maintaining a fiscally responsible budget and discussed the importance of balancing operational needs with long-term reserve preservation. He emphasized careful financial planning and accountability throughout the budget process.

Dorothy Yetter, Josephine County, commented on the Budget Committee's review process and the considerable work involved in evaluating the proposed budget. She encouraged continued transparency and responsible financial management while supporting the budget recommendations developed by the committee.

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-025; In the Matter of Adopting the Fiscal Year 2026-2027 Budget and Making Appropriations for Josephine County, Oregon, including the following amendments: Addition of **\$124,600** and **one full-time Help Desk Support Technician** within the Information Technology budget; Addition of **\$44,000** and **one half-time Law Library Assistant** within the Law Library budget, Seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Arthur O'Hare Budget Officer presented the fourth supplemental budget for Fiscal Year 2025-2026, noting that the Budget Committee approved the supplemental budget on June 9, 2026, publication requirements had been satisfied, and the matter was now before the Board for final adoption.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-026; In the Matter of Adopting a Supplemental Budget and Making Appropriations and Budget Adjustments for the Fiscal Year 2025-26, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

Commissioner Richardson made a motion to approve Resolution No. 2026-029 In the Matter of Levying Ad Valorem Property Tax Rates and Local Option Levy Taxes for Josephine County, Oregon for Fiscal Year

2026-27, Seconded by Commissioner Martin. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0

Public Hearing closed at 9:45 a.m.

7. REQUESTS/COMMENTS FROM CITIZENS: *(Each person will be given three (3) minutes to speak)*

Kristin Bryke, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Dam Removal.

Victor, Grants Pass, spoke in support of current hire.

Mark Jones, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

Libby Watts, Grants Pass, spoke in favor of the approval of the budget.

Arden Sled, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

Bernice Strange, Josephine County, spoke in favor of code enforcement and presented the Board with Photographs of a Business in rural area with out permits.

Joseph Crow, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

Herman Bertreger Senior, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

Gene Cologne, Josephine County, spoke in favor of code enforcement.

Judy Aherns, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal and Declaration of Independence Reading for 4th of July event.

Steve Strange, Josephine County, spoke in favor of code enforcement.

Thoren Alberston, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

Andrea Applegate, Josephine County, spoke in opposition to the matter of the Murphy Dam Removal.

BOARD MAY REVIEW PUBLIC COMMENTS/QUESTIONS:

8. APPROVAL OF CONSENT CALENDAR:

a. Minutes *(Draft minutes are available for viewing in the Board's Office)*

Admin Workshop – June 16, 2026

Weekly Business Session – June 17, 2026

Commissioner Martin made a motion to approve the Consent Calendar, seconded by Commissioner Richardson. Upon roll call, Commissioner Richardson – yes, Commissioner Martin – yes, Commissioner Smith – yes. Motion carried 3-0.

9. OTHER: (ORS 192.640(1)) “. . . notice shall include a list of the principal subjects anticipated to be considered at the meeting, but this requirement shall not limit the ability of a governing body to consider additional subjects.”)

10. ANNOUNCEMENTS: MATTERS FROM COMMISSIONERS:

Commissioner Richardson encouraged residents to sign up for emergency notifications and familiarize themselves with evacuation zones during wildfire season. Commissioner Smith thanked local firefighting agencies for their rapid response to a recent wildfire and commended emergency personnel for preventing further damage during challenging fire conditions.

Weekly Business Session adjourned at 10:32 a.m.



Nikole Guzman, Recorder

Exhibit 1- Proceedings to Legalize a Portion of Caves Camp Road No. 4120

Exhibit 2- Photographs of a Business in rural area

*Weekly Business Session
June 24, 2026
Exhibit 1, 2026*

Public Hearing Caves Camp Road Legalization Proceedings

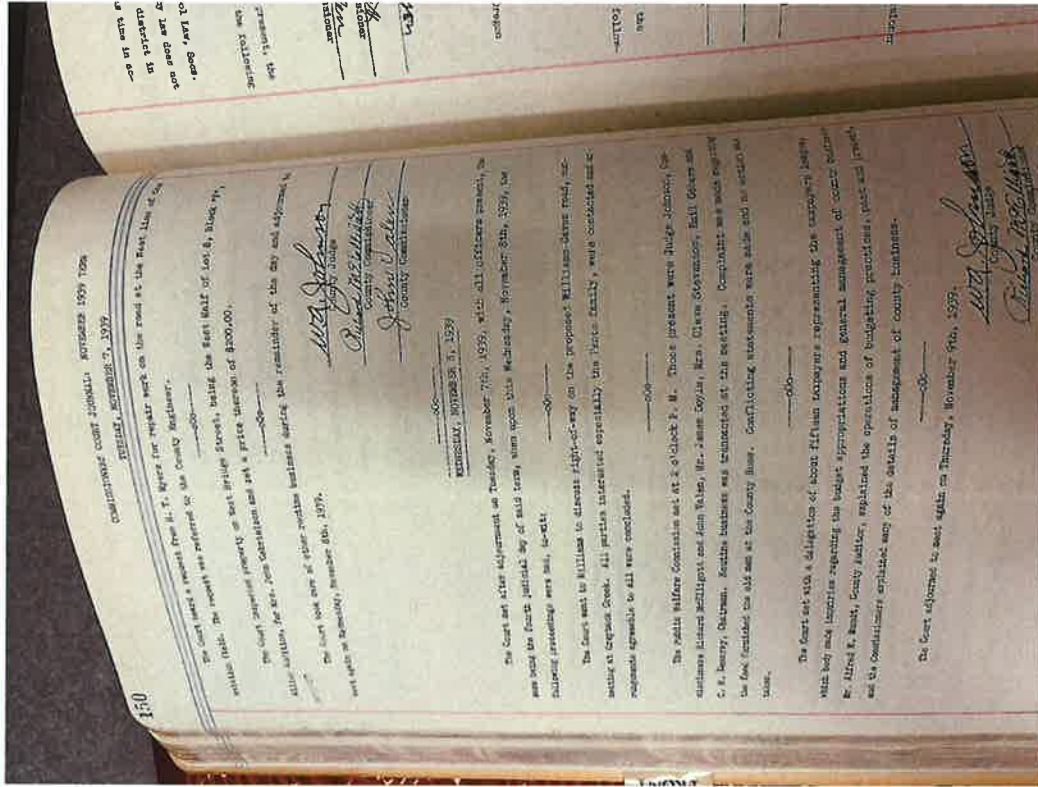
June 24, 2026

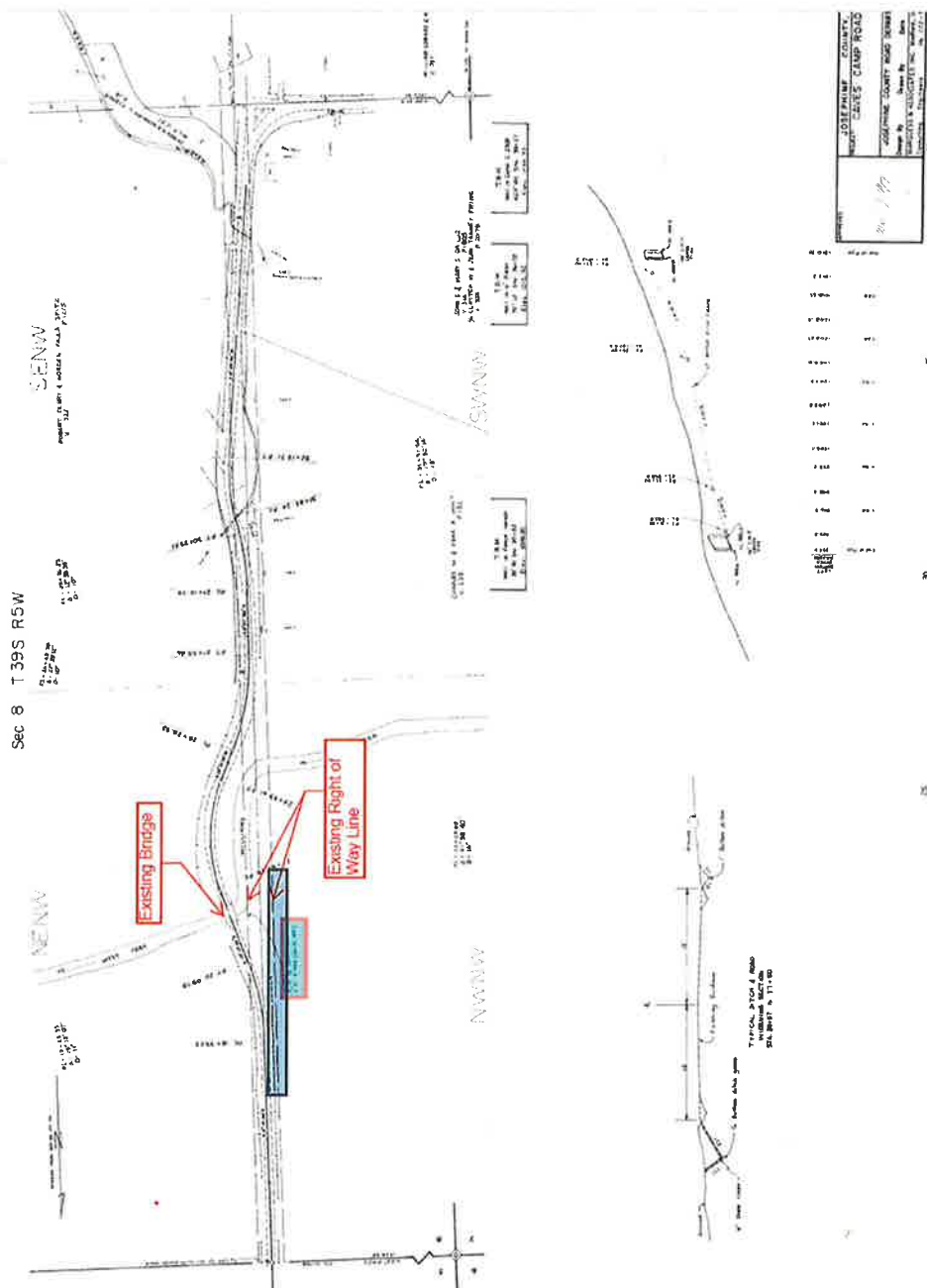




T. 395. R. 03 W.M.







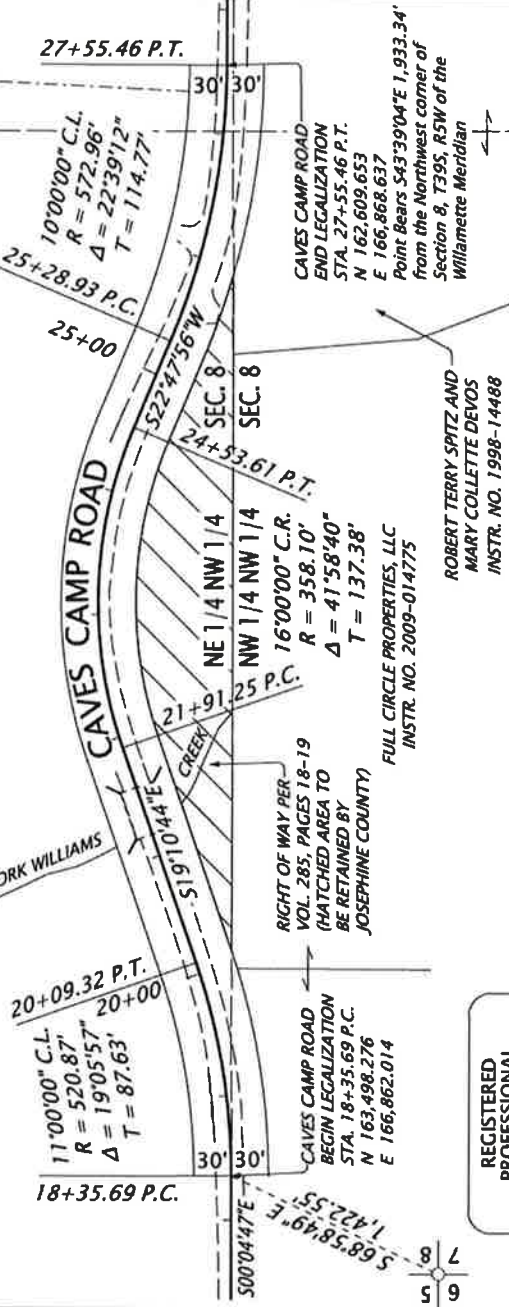


LEGALIZATION EXHIBIT MAP "B"
CAVES CAMP ROAD - WEST FORK WILLIAMS CREEK BRIDGE

NW 1/4 SECTION 8
TOWNSHIP 39 SOUTH, RANGE 5 WEST, WILLAMETTE MERIDIAN
JOSEPHINE COUNTY, OREGON

RAYMOND S. LABELLE
INSTR. NO. 2019-008424

JONATHAN KOVALCIK
INSTR. NO. 2004-028600



REGISTERED
PROFESSIONAL
LAND SURVEYOR

2026.02.26
Digitally Signed 14:40:22 -08'00'

OREGON
JULY 15, 2003
ANDREW DAVID AUSLAND
56136

EXPIRES: 12/31/2027



SCALE 1" = 100'



OREGON DEPARTMENT OF TRANSPORTATION



LEGALIZATION EXHIBIT MAP "B"
CAVES CAMP ROAD
JOSEPHINE COUNTY

ODOT REGION 3 TECH CENTER
100 ANTELOPE ROAD
WHITE CITY, OR 97503 KEY NO. 22662
FEBRUARY 26, 2026
SCALE: 1" = 100'
SHEET 1 OF 1

Overview

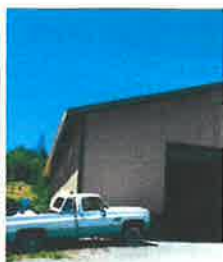
Reviews

By owner

Services

A

Weekly Business Session
June 24, 2020
Exhibit 2.



Call



Directions



Share



Save

Repair shop specializing in mufflers alongside auto repairs such as transmissions and engine diagnostics.



5788 Riverbanks Rd, Grants
Pass, OR 97527



Open · Closes 5:30 PM

4:29



Yelp



Search inside image



